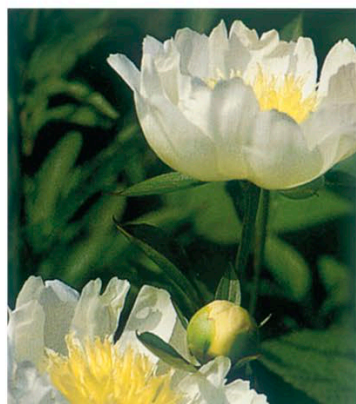


Paeonia lactiflora syn. *P. albiflora* (Paeoniaceae)

White Peony, Chinese Peony, Bai Shao Yao (Chinese)

White peony's history of medicinal use in China stretches back for at least 1,500 years. It is known most widely as one of the herbs used to make "Four Things Soup," a female tonic, and it is also a remedy for gynecological problems and for cramps, pain, and dizziness. Traditionally, it is considered that women who take the herb on a regular basis become as radiant as the flower itself.



White peony is cultivated for its root, which is a hormonal tonic, and for its flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation

White peony is cultivated throughout northeastern China and Inner Mongolia. It is propagated from seed in spring, or from root cuttings taken in winter. The root of 4- or 5-year-old plants is harvested in spring or autumn.

Related Species

P. suffruticosa, also commonly used in East Asian herbal medicine, and peony (*P. officinalis*, p. 243), a European species, have broadly similar properties to white peony.

Key Constituents

- Monoterpenoid glycosides (paeoniflorin, albiflorin)
- Benzoic acid
- Pentagalloyl glucose

Key Actions

- Antispasmodic
- Anti-inflammatory
- Enhances cognition
- Lowers blood pressure

Research

■ **Paeoniflorin** White peony has significant anti-inflammatory and antispasmodic properties, and preclinical research indicates that its traditional use for problems such as rheumatoid arthritis is justified. Paeoniflorin, the constituent most responsible for these effects, is also thought to lower blood pressure and support blood flow to the heart.

■ **Polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS)** White peony has a hormone-balancing activity that helps to reverse the symptoms of PCOS, which include irregular menstruation and infertility. In combination with licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101) it has been shown to support regular ovulation and to lower the raised testosterone levels that typically occur in PCOS.

■ **Supports cognition** There is accumulating evidence that white peony supports mental function, including spatial awareness and memory. Although no clinical trials have yet been published, white peony appears to have a strong neuroprotective effect within the brain.

■ **Cold sores** Pentagalloyl glucose may have an antiviral action against the cold sore virus, herpes simplex.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Four Things Soup** White peony is regarded primarily as a women's herb. Together with rehmannia (*Rehmannia glutinosa*, p. 125), chuan xiong (*Ligusticum wallachii*), and dong quai (*Angelica sinensis*, p. 63), it is an ingredient in "Four Things Soup,"

Parts Used

Root has important tonic and pain-relieving properties. It is boiled and dried for use in a wide range of preparations.



Dried root



Root has antispasmodic properties

Fresh root

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Caution** Do not take during pregnancy.



Decoction (to make, p. 291) helps relieve period pain, heavy bleeding, and other menstrual disorders. To relieve period pain, take ½ cup (75 ml) 3 times a day.

Four things soup (to make, see p. 315). Drink ¾ cup (150 ml) daily as a general tonic.



Dong quai

Rehmannia

Chuan xiong

White peony

the most widely used female tonic in China.

■ **Gynecological remedy** White peony helps menstrual disorders, including heavy bleeding and bleeding between periods, and is specifically used to treat period pain and cramps. It is a blood and yin tonic

(see pp. 40–41) and will help "blood deficiency" states, as well as hot flashes and night sweats.

Self-help Uses

- **Heavy menstrual bleeding**, p. 315.
- **Hot flashes & night sweats**, p. 316.
- **Period pain**, p. 315.